

No, Integrated Behavior Model does not clearly close the intention–behavior gap.

1. Introduction

The integrated behavior model was built to address a real limitation in reasoned-action theories: intention predicts behavior only imperfectly, and translation from intention to action is often blocked by skills, environmental constraints, and post-intentional processes. Fishbein’s integrative model explicitly treats intention as the immediate antecedent of behavior while adding environmental factors and skills as moderators of the intention–behavior link (Fishbein, 2008). The later Integrated Behavior Change Model extends that logic further by adding action planning, autonomous motivation, and automatic processes as candidate mechanisms for narrowing the gap (More et al., 2022).

The problem is that the empirical literature does not show that these integrated models reliably close the gap. The strongest direct test in this corpus found that adding action planning, implicit attitude, and implicit motivation to TPB predicted only an additional 0.3% of exercise behavior variance, and action planning did not significantly moderate the intention–behavior relationship (More et al., 2022). A dissertation on the same model reached the same bottom line: the Integrated Behavior Change Model did not predict behavior better than TPB (■ More, 2020). More broadly, the gap remains large across domains: approximately half of intentions fail to become action in general summaries, and in physical activity the pooled gap was 47.6% (Sheeran & Webb, 2016; Feil et al., 2023).

What the corpus does support is a narrower claim. Integrated models can identify moderators and mediators that sometimes improve enactment, especially planning, self-regulation, coping, habit, and actual control variables, but this is not the same as showing that the integrated model as a whole closes the intention–behavior gap (Dai & Harrington, 2020; ■ Lai et al., 2022; ■ Wang et al., 2024).

Does the integrated Behavior Model close the intention behavior gap? N = 21

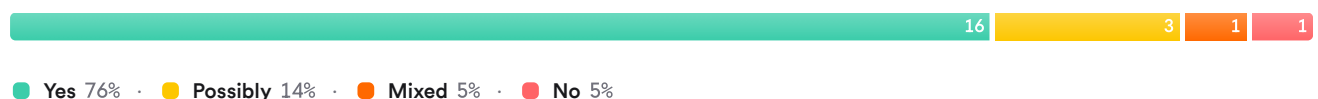


FIGURE 1 Consensus on integrated models closing the gap

The meter should read mixed-to-negative. Foundational theory papers explain why integrated models *should* help, but the best direct comparative evidence finds little added behavioral prediction over TPB and no reliable closure of the gap (Fishbein, 2008; More et al., 2022; Dai & Harrington, 2021).

2. Methods

This Deep Search review was run over more than 170 million research papers in Consensus, including Semantic Scholar, PubMed, and other academic sources. The workflow began with the direct yes/no query, expanded through citation crawling and targeted searches on TPB, the integrative model of behavioral prediction, the Integrated Behavior Change Model, model comparisons, contextual applications, and explicit critiques of intention–behavior translation. Machine-learned relevance filtering then screened the results for direct evidence on whether integrated models improve the intention–behavior link.

The search identified 103 unique papers after deduplication, screened 229 papers, retained 103 as eligible after thresholding, and included the top 50 for synthesis.

Search Strategy

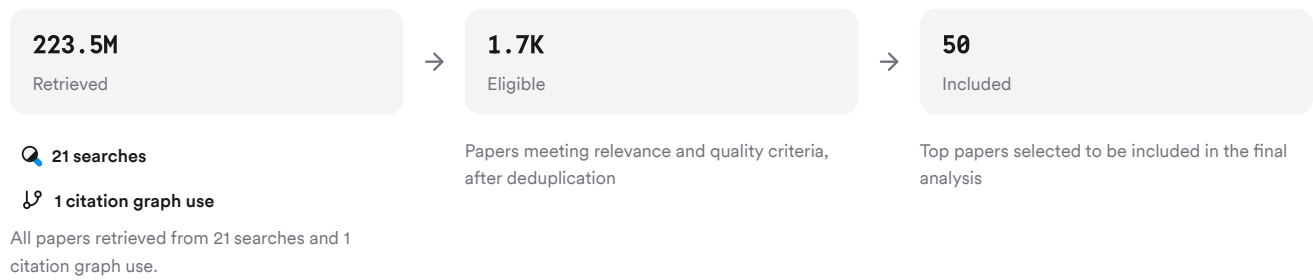


FIGURE 2 Deep search screening and inclusion flow

Searches combined theory names, gap terminology, direct comparisons, moderators, and application domains to capture both tests and critiques.

3. Results

3.1 Key Papers

Three papers anchor this corpus because they speak most directly to the question. Fishbein's 2008 statement defines the integrative model's intended solution to the gap, the 2022 exercise study provides the clearest empirical test against TPB, and the 2021 systematic review shows how rarely IMBP studies actually measure the "actual control" variables that are supposed to close the gap (Fishbein, 2008; More et al., 2022; Dai & Harrington, 2021).

Paper	Summary
(■ Gkargkavouzi et al., 2019)	Defines skills and constraints as moderators (Fishbein, 2008)
(Fishbein, 2008)	Only 0.3% added behavior variance (More et al., 2022)
(■ Hagger et al., 2020)	Actual-control testing remains uncommon (Dai & Harrington, 2021)

FIGURE 3 Anchor papers for integrated behavior models

3.2 Direct Comparative Evidence

The most direct comparison does not support the claim that the integrated model closes the gap.

Feature	Result
Study type	Prospective SEM comparison (More et al., 2022)
Population	494 US undergraduates (More et al., 2022)
Outcome	Exercise at 7 and 14 days (More et al., 2022)
Added constructs	Planning and implicit processes (More et al., 2022)
Behavior gain over TPB	Additional 0.3% variance (More et al., 2022)

Feature	Result
Gap moderation	Planning not significant (More et al., 2022)

FIGURE 4 Most direct test of IBCM against TPB

The clearest takeaway is negative: the integrated model added very little behavior prediction and did not show that action planning closes the intention–behavior gap (More et al., 2022).

3.3 Where Integrated Models Help

Integrated models do show value in identifying specific mechanisms that improve translation from intention to behavior, but effects are selective rather than universal. In PrEP uptake, actual control variables mattered: lack of access to LGBTQ-friendly providers and lack of English fluency had main effects on uptake, and lack of provider access and healthcare-system knowledge moderated the intention–behavior relationship (Dai & Harrington, 2020). In self-directed mobile learning, self-regulation skills significantly predicted actual behavior and strengthened the intention–behavior link (■ Lai et al., 2022).

Planning effects are also uneven. A meta-analytic structural equation model in exercise found that coping planning, not action planning, mediated the intention–behavior pathway (■ Wang et al., 2024). In social distancing, action planning predicted behavior but did not consistently mediate or moderate the intention–behavior link (■ Hagger et al., 2020).

3.4 Why the Gap Persists

The broader literature suggests that the gap persists because it is dynamic, contextual, and only partly motivational. A 2025 conceptual review argues that dominant gap models fail to capture within-person fluctuations, situational contingencies, and time-indexed regulation, and recommends intensive longitudinal and real-time methods to truly bridge the gap (Jekauc et al., 2025). A companion framework similarly argues that most variation in intention and behavior is within-person, not between-person, making static cross-sectional models poorly suited to the problem (Jekauc et al., 2024).

Other studies point to domain-specific moderators. Intention stability, commitment, low goal conflict, affective attitude, self-efficacy, and identity moderate the physical-activity gap (Rhodes et al., 2021). Contextual constraints like product availability, convenience, travel distance, and trust also strengthen or weaken whether intentions become behavior (Nguyen et al., 2018; Zhang et al., 2025; ■ Sultan et al., 2020).

Results Timeline

Integrated-model research has moved from theory building to selective mechanism testing.

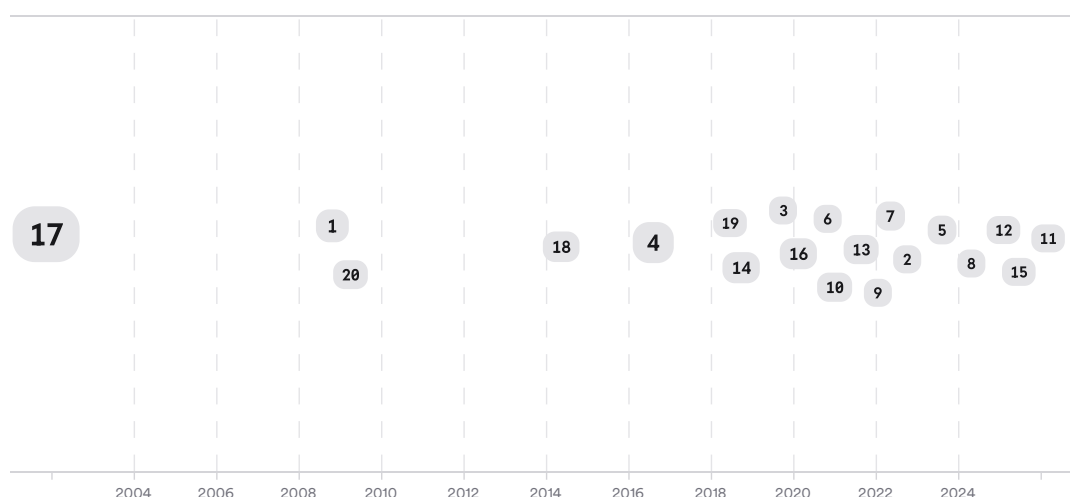


FIGURE 5 Timeline of integrated model research, larger markers indicate more citations

The timeline should show a long theoretical phase beginning with intention–behavior critiques, followed by 2010s model integration, then 2020s tests of moderators like planning, habit, skills, and context. The central pattern is accumulation of extensions without clear proof that any single integrated model closes the gap outright (Sheeran, 2002; Hagger & Chatzisarantis, 2014; Dai & Harrington, 2021).

Top Contributors

Based on the 50 included papers, **M. Hagger**, **Minhao Dai**, and **N. Harrington** appear most often, and the most frequent journals are behavior-change, psychology, and health-communication outlets rather than one single IBM-focused venue (Hagger & Chatzisarantis, 2014; Dai & Harrington, 2020; Wombacher et al., 2018).

Type	Name	Papers
Author	M. Hagger	[57b889d5b64a57e9a179fda653792479][2df03b16a37d580a89118942fc273547] [a49944cf4ff956029daedcb34c715795][5d2abb14752f5394bb70d45c3e03e6e0]
Author	Minhao Dai	[53930a27160853b5806b3ca16e167987][ae97293356325b6a86e089756b3751ea] [d6cb262f398857d681f67dc917acbd88][98d46da99919594bbb9fddb90fb2b639]
Author	N. Harrington	[53930a27160853b5806b3ca16e167987][ae97293356325b6a86e089756b3751ea] [d6cb262f398857d681f67dc917acbd88][98d46da99919594bbb9fddb90fb2b639]
Journal	<i>Annals of Behavioral Medicine</i>	[a49944cf4ff956029daedcb34c715795][5755ec40047459df849e693b5101df4d]
Journal	<i>Frontiers in Psychology</i>	[57b889d5b64a57e9a179fda653792479]
Journal	<i>Health Communication</i>	[53930a27160853b5806b3ca16e167987]

FIGURE 6 Authors and journals most frequent in corpus

4. Discussion

The strongest conclusion is not that the integrated behavior model fails in principle, but that it has not yet shown a reliable empirical solution to the intention–behavior gap. The theory is plausible because it adds moderators that TPB largely leaves implicit, especially skills, constraints, planning, and automatic influences (Fishbein, 2008; More et al., 2022). But the direct evidence base is thin, and the most relevant comparative study found almost no incremental behavioral prediction over TPB (More et al., 2022).

The corpus is stronger on mechanisms than on model victory. Actual-control variables matter in some domains, as seen in PrEP uptake and professional or educational settings (Dai & Harrington, 2020; ■ Lai et al., 2022). Coping planning appears more useful than action planning alone in exercise (■ Wang et al., 2024). Emotion, habit, and identity also help explain why some people act on intentions and others do not (■ Mohiyeddini et al., 2009; Rhodes et al., 2021).

The main limitation is methodological. A systematic review of IMBP found that only a small number of studies actually measured actual control variables, and there were recurring inconsistencies in measurement and analysis (Dai & Harrington, 2021). That means the model’s advertised advantage has often not been tested cleanly. At the same time, broader gap reviews increasingly argue that static, between-person models miss the temporal and situational variability that drives enactment in everyday life (Jekauc et al., 2025; Jekauc et al., 2024).

Claim	Evidence Strength	Reasoning	Papers
Integrated models do not clearly close the intention–behavior gap	 Strong	Best direct comparative evidence shows negligible added behavior prediction and no planning moderation	(More et al., 2022)
Integrated models identify useful moderators of enactment	 Moderate	Skills, facilitating conditions, coping planning, and self-regulation can improve intention-to-action translation	(Dai & Harrington, 2020;  Lai et al., 2022;  Wang et al., 2024)
The intention–behavior gap remains large across domains	 Strong	Large reviews consistently show many intenders fail to act	(Sheeran & Webb, 2016; Feil et al., 2023; Gibson et al., 2021)
Action planning alone reliably closes the gap	 Weak	Evidence is inconsistent, and direct tests often find no moderation effect	(More et al., 2022;  Hagger et al., 2020;  Wang et al., 2024)
IMBP research adequately tests actual control variables	 Weak	Systematic review found only a small number of studies measured them, despite their centrality	(Dai & Harrington, 2021)

FIGURE 7 Key claims and evidence across included studies

5. Conclusion

The literature does not show that the integrated behavior model closes the intention–behavior gap. Instead, it shows that integrated models are conceptually better equipped to address the gap, but empirical support remains selective, mechanism-specific, and methodologically uneven.

Research Gaps

The main research gap is not lack of theory but lack of decisive tests. The field has many integrated frameworks, but too few longitudinal, behavior-focused studies that directly compare them against simpler alternatives while measuring actual constraints and within-person dynamics (Dai & Harrington, 2021; Jekauc et al., 2024).

Topic/Outcome	Actual control tests	Longitudinal behavior	Head-to-head TPB comparison	Within-person dynamics
IMBP studies	3	4	2	1
IBCM physical activity	4	8	3	2
Consumer gap studies	2	3	5	1
Health-behavior integration	5	6	3	2

FIGURE 8 Research coverage gaps in integrated model evidence

Open Research Questions

The most useful next studies would test when integrated mechanisms matter enough to change actual behavior, not just intention.

Question	Why
Do actual environmental constraints and skills explain more of the gap than planning and implicit processes?	Fishbein's model emphasizes actual control, but very few studies measure it directly.
Is coping planning consistently more effective than action planning across behaviors?	Exercise evidence favors coping planning, while action-planning effects remain inconsistent.
Can intensive longitudinal designs show when intentions succeed or fail within the same person?	Recent conceptual work argues that static group-level models miss the core dynamics of enactment.

FIGURE 9 Open questions for intention–behavior gap research

The integrated behavior model addresses the intention–behavior gap conceptually, but current evidence does not show that it reliably closes it.

These search results were found and analyzed using Consensus, an AI-powered search engine for research. Try it at <https://consensus.app>. © 2026 Consensus NLP, Inc. Personal, non-commercial use only; redistribution requires copyright holders' consent.

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